NCERT

EDITING HISTORY

Selective deletions of significant passages in textbooks on Indian history in the name of rationalisation of school curricula once again stoke fears of the politicisation of education

By KAUSHIK DEKA

ON **writing about the past,** Winston S. Churchill once wryly remarked, "History will be kind to me, for I intend to write it." What the former British premier said in jest is being hurled at the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in earnest as a huge controversy has erupted over revisions in the textbooks for middle and high school students, which the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) released for students earlier this month. Accusations flew thick and fast over the changes, particularly with regard to recent history, as critics accused the Narendra Modi government of using the country's premier curriculum-setting body to whitewash events that are uncomfortable for the saffron dispensation. The NCERT defended its actions saying the deletions were made public last June and were part of a "rationalisation process" to ease the curriculum load on students and help them make a "speedy recovery" from the learning disruptions caused during the Covid-19 pandemic. It also said its changes were in line with what was laid down in the National Education Policy (NEP), 2020, asking for a reduction in content. As a result, the NCERT has trimmed almost 30 per cent of the syllabus across subjects in the past five years.

The changes had sparked a furore among experts last year as well: they cited crucial deletions, particularly from the history and political science textbooks, including an entire chapter on the Mughals, references to caste-based inequality under the varna system, Dalit movements and their struggles, interventions and poetry, the Nehruvian era of governance, the Emergency, the 2002 Gujarat riots and the Naxalite movements. The critics slammed it as another attempt by the BJP-led Union government to "saffronise" history. The flames of that controversy were fanned again as the new textbooks with the deletions reached school students for the 2023-24 academic year. Experts found that additional portions had been erased, ones that had not found mention in the list of "rationalised" content released last June.

Among the more contentious deletions made without prior intimation are the references to earlier attempts to assassinate Mahatma Gandhi by Hindu extremist groups, the ban on the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) following his actual assassination and his killer Nathuram Godse's identity as a Brahmin and editor of a Hindu extremist magazine. In the first chapter of the political science textbook *Politics in India Since Independence* for Class 12 students, the following portion under the subhead 'Mahatma Gandhi's Sacrifice' was deleted: "He (Gan-